from these unequal treaties and would be prepared to negotiate a new relationship to safeguard legitimate interests of both parties.

Zhou framed this in terms of 'principle' and proposed that both sides first reach a consensus on this 'principle'. If India agreed to this principle, Zhou suggested that the first concrete issue to be resolved was the nature of the Lhasa Mission. He proposed that the Lhasa Mission be re-designated as a Consulate General, and that China be permitted to open a reciprocal office in Bombay (Mumbai). He added that all other matters like post and telegraph facilities, military escorts and trade marts were 'technical' issues that could be left for later negotiation because China did not want to create a vacuum in Tibet as a result of any changes to these arrangements. He never referred to the India–China (Tibet) boundary at all. [26]

On the face of it, the principle was unexceptionable and the change in nomenclature of Indian presence in Tibet appeared to be a matter of re-designation. It was, in fact, the nub of the discussion. The proposal would not only change the legal status of the Indian presence in Tibet, it would, as Zhou Enlai told Zhang Jingwu, end the old relationship between India and Tibet forever. [27] This was classic Chinese salami-slicing tactics. Zhou's proposals had serious implications for India. If the Chinese maintained, as a matter of principle, that all previous treaties were invalid and a new relationship had to be negotiated, then it automatically followed that the Simla Agreement of 1914 was also no longer valid and the McMahon Line was illegal. It blew the Indian argument that the McMahon Line was the final boundary between India and Tibet (now China) right out of the water.

Panikkar, however, pointed out that Zhou Enlai had not questioned the alignment of the frontier and strongly recommended that as the frontier had already been defined by